

Marriage

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MARRIAGE

If you have someone who loves you, you've got it made.

—CHARLES BOATWRIGHT, Study Interview

MENTAL HEALTH AND THE CAPACITY to love are linked, but the linkages are elusive. We can't weigh love on a scale, or examine it with special lenses. Poets can encompass it up to a point, but for most of us, psychologists and psychiatrists included, it's something of a mystery. The importance of intimate, warm, mutual attachment (not just sex, and not even the biological/instinctual drive often called Eros) is the third lesson of the Grant Study. But no aspect of human behavior is assessed more subjectively, or measured less easily, than intimacy.

Fortunately this doesn't stop us from enjoying love anyway—not only in its passionate aspects, but also in the enduring warmth and comfort of close relationship. Here, for instance, is Charles Boatwright at age eighty-five on the pleasures of his second marriage: "Really just being together. Share each other's lives and our children's lives. Snuggle on cold nights." Jim Hart, who at eighty-one participated with his wife, Julia, in director Robert Waldinger's Study of Marital Intimacy, told the Study that she was the essence of his life, and called their relationship "a lovely, lovely partnership." What are his hopes for his marriage? "I want it to stay like it is," Jim says. "Period. It can't get better." Julia's view of it? They're best friends, and there's a physical relationship, if not quite what it was when they were young. But the main thing is: "I adore him. More than I ever did. We laugh a lot. We laugh at ourselves. . . . You can't take yourself too seriously. . . . I don't know how we got here, but it's wonderful."

This kind of pleasure in the company of another person is quite different from Eriksonian Intimacy as we dealt with it in the last chapter, and throughout this chapter I'll be making a distinction between the two. Eriksonian Intimacy, like puberty, is a developmental task. It comes later to some people than others, but most of us get there. As fledglings fly from the parental nest, we all must leave our parents' homes and establish ourselves emotionally in the peer world, sharing space, money, decisions, plans, and other issues of mutual interdependence. The Harvard Study of Adult Development defined Eriksonian Intimacy operationally as ten years of living in an interdependent and committed relationship. But that commitment can take very different forms.

Eriksonian Intimacy is an intimacy of physical and practical proximity. The emotional intimacy of deep relatedness is different. Some couples have a shared emotional economy. There's a constant circulation between them; they're under each other's skin, and happy to have it so. This isn't the blurred boundary of codependency; it's a mutuality based on a clear sense of self and other. But it is a knack, like the huge hand-span of a great pianist. Not everyone has it or wants it, and it is not necessary for a fulfilling life.

This chapter will address four questions: What does emotional intimacy look like? What can we learn from marriages that have endured for fifty years or more? What can we learn from marriages that don't endure? And what do intimacy and mental health have to do with each other?

Investigation of the Grant Study marriages was an eye-opener for me. Although I stand by my rash assertion to *The Atlantic* that relationship (that is, the capacity for loving attachment) is what matters most in life, I can't quite say the same for this pronouncement from my first book: "In the Grant Study, there was probably no single longitudinal variable that predicted mental health as clearly as a man's capacity to remain happily married over time." ¹ In 1977, I firmly believed that divorce boded statistically ill for future development and future happiness. But it has since become clear that this was yet another premature conclusion.

Before I proceed, here in Table 6.1 is a summary of the Grant Study men's marital histories. We'll be referring to it as we go on.

As you can see, these numbers include all marriages either through 2010, or until one of the partners died. One hundred and seventy-three of the men's first marriages remained intact, including fifty-one happy ones, seventy-three average ones (which we called "so-so"), and forty-nine unhappy ones. Seventy-four men, including twenty-three of the sixty-two who once divorced, contracted very happy remarriages that have stayed that way through 2010, or through the death of a partner. The thirty-seven remaining divorced men either did not remarry or remarried unhappily.

Table 6.1 Life Course of Study Marriages (1940 through 2010, or until the death of one partner)

* 26 of the 268 original Study members were excluded from Table 6.1 . Four of them died in the war, three never married, and 19 withdrew from the Study.

** One man who lived happily all his life with another man in a close interdependent relationship was classified as "Still married; very happy."

The mean length of marriage for the surviving couples still in their first and only marriage was over sixty years. That's a nice statistic, if not a surprising one. But the mean length of remarriage for the twenty-three divorced but happily remarried men was almost thirty-five years, a finding that required me, as I will recount in a moment, to rethink de novo my assumptions about divorce, mental health, and the capacity for intimacy.

RATING MARRIAGES

How did we know who was happily married and who wasn't? The short answer is: the men told us, repeatedly. Cynics may wonder how many of them were Pollyannas like Boatwright, or possibly even outright liars. But we had decades of prospective follow-up in our files; there was plenty of objective information against which to test their subjective reports. I don't contend that men in the Study never lied to us or to themselves about their marriages, but it is hard to maintain deception for fifty years and more.

Where did our information come from? Qualitative responses to questionnaires and interviews were a major source. The men's wives were sent questionnaires, too. Most couples were interviewed together at about age thirty. After that there were no planned couple interviews (although there were some adventitious ones) until Study director Robert Waldinger began interviewing the surviving men and their wives together and separately on videotape. The recordings—another forward-looking investment—are being saved for future study. 2 In scoring responses, we always used multiple independent raters, each blind to all other information about the men. That way we avoided the halo effects that can plague longitudinal studies, where raters' assessments are contaminated by what they know about successes or failures in the past.

A second source was multiple-choice questions. To quantify elusive intuitions about marital satisfaction, we asked husbands to complete a simple multiple-choice scale on five questionnaires between their thirty-fifth and seventieth years. Wives did the same three times, between the ages of forty-five and sixty-five. The four questions whose answers correlated most highly with marital satisfaction were: 3

1. Solutions to disagreements generally come: 1=easily, 2=moderately hard, 3=always difficult, 4=we go on without a solution

2. How stable do you think your marriage is? 1=quite stable, 2=some minor weaknesses, 3=moderate weaknesses, 4=major weaknesses, 5=not stable

3. Sexual adjustment is, on the whole: 1=very satisfying, 2=satisfying, 3=at times not as good as wished, 4=rather poor

4. Separation or divorce has been considered: 1=never, 2=only casually, 3=seriously

The scores on these four questions were summed into a global assessment of marital adjustment: the lower the score, the happier the marriage.

The men's own subjective ratings were a third source of data; three times between the ages of seventy and ninety they rated their marriages on a scale of 1 (very unhappy) to 6 (very happy).

At about sixty, the husbands and wives filled out a chart in which they retrospectively rated their marriages in five-year chunks as: 1 =Very enjoyable, 2=Not one of the very best periods, 3=Rocky, 4=Divorce considered.

Our final way of assessing the Study marriages was to look for comments the men made about them outside of specifically marriage-related contexts. This allowed us to test yet again the reliability of their multiple-choice statements. Here are some spontaneous comments made by men who scored their marriages poorly:

“She has an inferiority complex.”

“I am more affectionate than her.”

“She likes her beer.”

“It’s easier to suffer with her than without her.”

“We sleep in separate rooms.”

“When she throws the plates, I catch them. I never throw them back. When she hits me, I never hit her back.” (This man added, however, “Although I’ve slapped her to bring her to her senses”—a good example of a fifty-plus-year marriage that was scored as chronically unhappy.)

The following quotes were characteristic of happy marriages:

“My wife is the kindest and most considerate person I have ever known.”

“Our marriage is completely challenging, completely exciting.”

“Tennis doubles with my wife is my greatest enjoyment.”

“I am very proud of her.”

“I love and admire her; she is my best friend.”

“Our marriage is GREAT. My wife has been the best thing that ever happened to me.”

A dichotomy between good and bad marriages may be hard to establish when feelings are looked at moment to moment, but it is real enough over time.

There were two areas in which our data were weak. The men were loath to return questionnaires that inquired too specifically into their sex lives. Too much curiosity on our part was firmly ignored, and we had to settle for global generalizations. More on this in a bit. Also, the worse the marriage, the less information was forthcoming about it from either husband or wife, which limits my capacity to illustrate a very troubled marriage in a life study. Agatha Penn, for instance, declined to return any of the questionnaires sent to her, or otherwise participate in Study contacts. She also discouraged her husband from responding to inquiries sent to him.

A THIRTY-YEAR CHALLENGE

In 1977 I handed in the manuscript of *Adaptation to Life*. My editor at Little, Brown, Lewellen Howland, took issue with my contention that divorce was a serious indicator of poor mental health, and suggested gently, “George, it is not that divorce is bad; it is that loving people for a long time is good.” I liked his sentiment, but I didn’t believe him, despite the fact that I myself was in a happy second marriage at age forty. (We’re all the exceptions to our own rules.) The numbers I’d been working with for the previous ten years didn’t look promising at all. By 1967, seventeen men had divorced. By 1973, fourteen of them had been remarried for longer than a year. Of those fourteen second marriages, eight had already ended in divorce again—you’ll hear about two of those in a little while—and four more showed weaknesses that kept them securely out of the good marriage category. In other words, of the fourteen remarriages, only two looked to be anything like happy, and they were still too new to be trusted. Louie’s a romantic, I thought. All I have to do is wait for thirty years and I’ll be able to show him his error.

Fifteen years later I was still right and Howland was still wrong. When I checked marital history against the best and worst Adult Adjustment Outcome determinations that I had established for that 1977 book, all of the fifty-five Best Outcomes had gotten married relatively early and stayed married for most of their adult lives. (And by the time those men

were eighty-five, we learned later, only one marriage had ended in divorce.) In contrast, among the seventy-eight Worst Outcomes, five had never married, and by seventy-five years of age, thirty-five (45 percent) of the marriages had ended in divorce. Proportionately three times as many of the Best Adjusted men enjoyed lifelong happy marriages as the Worst Adjusted.

But as the first decade of the twenty-first century wound to a close, the men were well into their eighties and the Study was still going strong. And so were a bunch of second marriages. I could no longer get away with my flippant dismissal of Louie's rebuke. I was also intrigued by a growing sense that as the men got older they talked about their marriages differently. So in 2010, after many years of concentrating mostly on aging, I took another look at marriage. This time I was armed with a great deal of information about alcohol use among the men and their wives (which I'll detail in Chapter 9). And it turned out that Lewellen Howland was a very wise man.

Once again, the long picture was quite different from the shorterterm one. Not about everything. At eighty-five, twenty-six of the twenty-eight men with consistently happy first marriages reported that their marriages remained happy. Marriages that had been poor to start with tended to remain that way, whether they endured without divorce for fifty years or ended, still unhappy, in death. Of the thirty surviving men who had had unhappy marriages between twenty and eighty years of age, only five reported happy marriages after eighty. Four of these were new marriages, undertaken after the first wife had died. None of this was very startling (with the exception of the fifth husband's mysterious report that he and his wife were "still in love, mutually dependent and the best of friends"). But it was very startling, to me at least, that twenty-three of the twenty-seven surviving divorced and remarried men reported that their current marriages were happy—and had been for an average length of thirty-three years!

What magic had occurred in those final years to shed such a different light on the early statistics? None. It was just that a new calculation had cleared away a lot of obscuring underbrush. On second thought, though, maybe it was magic after all—the magic of lifetime study.

That calculation showed that the single most important factor in the Grant Study divorces was alcoholism; thirty-four of the divorces— 57 percent —had occurred when at least one spouse was abusing alcohol. I didn't uncover this fact until I included the wives' alcohol use in my marital calculations, and that information had been a very long time in the gathering. The men were much less forthcoming about their wives' drinking habits than their own. Statistics trickled in slowly, and as they did I had been sequestering them on yellow-lined paper in a folder all their own. One problem with the huge volume of longitudinal data is that it can drown even a computer if you dump everything in at once. So I didn't enter the wives' drinking data until they reached critical mass. The minute I did, however, alcohol leaped out at me as a new and extremely important consideration.

When I made my categorical 1977 statement on divorce, the data had suggested that marriages fail due to immaturity of coping mechanisms, poor relationship skills, and evidence of mental illness. Divorce itself, it appeared, was evidence of poor mental health that would surely make itself felt again in future attempts at marriage. 4 (Here as always I'm using our standard rough gauges of mental health problems—immature coping style, abuse of alcohol, heavy recourse to psychotherapy or other psychiatric care, use of antidepressants and tranquilizers, and so on.) There were very powerful associations between all of these and divorce. But as always, association and causation are not the same thing. In 2010, when I controlled for alcoholism for the first time, the three alleged 1977 causes of bad marriage ceased to be significant. In fact, it looked very much as though alcoholism in a marriage often caused not only the divorce, but also the failed relationships, the poor coping style, and the evidence of shaky mental health. Yet alcoholism does not even appear in the index of two landmark 500-plus-page books on marriage, Lewis Terman's 1938 *Psychological Factors in Marital Happiness* and John Gottman's 1994 *What Predicts Divorce?* 5 These works, separated by more than fifty years, are important exemplars of how influential researchers think about marriage, one from the time of the Study's inception, and the other from the days of its maturity. Alcoholism is still, arguably, the most ignored causal factor in modern social science, and it took the Grant Study sixty-eight years to notice that it was the most important cause of failed marriage. 6

So it was back to the drawing board for me. In 1977 I had viewed divorce as a failure in the capacity for intimacy. But by 2010 I knew (and will demonstrate in Chapter 9) that alcoholism is not "a good man's failing," but a chronic and relapsing disease; not a matter of personality, but very often of genes.

Once it is clear that divorce sometimes (indeed, frequently) reflects factors other than the partners' emotional immaturity, it is easier to understand that is not necessarily a predictor of future troubled relationships, and that previously divorced men are capable of long and happy marriages after all.

These findings raise some interesting issues, which will undoubtedly be tested once the necessary lifetime studies are available. From my point of view, however, the take-home lesson is the great power of the Grant Study's unique approach to diagnosing alcoholism over time by means of behavioral longitudinal data. You can't measure obesity by asking someone how much he ate last week; people with weight problems are often on diets. You have to get them on a scale. The Study didn't try to make quantitative estimates of how much or how often the men drank. But as time passed, repeated questions about what problems the men had with their drinking made abuse of alcohol ever more clear.

The wives' issues with alcohol, as I've said, were trickier; a gentleman doesn't reveal his wife's weight, and apparently he doesn't say much about her drinking, either. And we had no direct behavioral information from the wives themselves. So it took a long time for this dramatic correlation to come into focus. But once we did, it was very clear that alcohol is the 800-pound gorilla in any study of marital failure. I will mention it in passing here when it comes up, but Chapter 9 is devoted to an extensive study of alcohol abuse and its hugely destructive effects on individual and interpersonal development.

These two related findings (the implication of alcohol and the exculpation of divorce) point up yet again the crucial importance of long-term follow-up in any research where the passage of time is at issue. As far back as 1951 researchers had begun to acknowledge that their studies of marriage were limited by the cross-sectional nature of the available data, and had sent out a call for longitudinal investigations. But as we've seen repeatedly, prospective material seldom comes easily, and it never comes fast. Field and Wieshaus pointed out that "[u]ntil recently marriages that endured 20 years or longer have been considered long-term. . . . It is very likely that a marriage of 40 years differs considerably from the same marriage at 20 years." ⁷ That comment encapsulates perfectly the truncated expectations of so much psychological and sociological research, and why, when a long perspective on marriage does become available, it is too valuable to neglect. The Grant Study's perspective is long enough to show us that at sixty years a marriage can turn into a partnership different from what had been twenty years before, for better or for worse; Leo Tolstoy's story is a notable example of a great marriage that turned sour after many decades and thirteen children. ⁸

THREE MARRIAGES

Now let me try to make these intangibles tangible. I'll use case histories, commentary from independent observers, and long-term follow-up to illustrate a very happy and lasting marriage, a very happy and lasting remarriage, and a long marriage that endured in the absence of either conflict or tenderness.

Fredrick and Catherine Chipp: Even the mosquitoes. Of the hundreds of responses we got when the Grant Study sent questionnaires out to the men's children in 1986, there was only one family in which all the children checked off that their parents' marriage was "[b]etter than my friends,' " That marriage was Fredrick and Catherine Chipp's. One daughter even scribbled in, "Much better."

By the time Fredrick Chipp was eighty, he (and his wife) had been giving their marriage rave reviews for six decades. The first time he met Catherine, the sixteen-year-old Chipp went home and told his mother, "I met the girl I'm going to marry." It took him a few years to get her to see it that way, but from then on, he says, "I've lived happily ever after." Not that there weren't changes along the way. When he was seventy-five, Chipp described in an interview how their relationship has evolved. "She has become more confident, and I have learned to adjust to that."

On their fiftieth wedding anniversary, he dug out the diary of his teenage years, in which he had described his future wife as "simply swell." The two of them started out sailing together. The day after our interview, sixty years later, they were planning to take off on vacation—two weeks of sailing. "I do the skilled and the nautical parts. I take charge—it's just instinct," Chipp said. Catherine enjoyed the aesthetics. Every year for decades they went canoeing together in Nova Scotia, too. Chipp told me solemnly, "That is important time." I've had readers complain that marriage isn't all vacation, and that stories like this don't tell us much about what the Chipps' life together was like. My answer to that is: to the Chipps, all of life was a vacation. They enjoyed every bit of it, including the mosquitoes, as long as they were battling them together. You could feel it when you were with them. (And, as Eben Frost's story below will remind you, in some

marriages even the vacations aren't idyllic.)

Yet they didn't live in each other's pockets. Once Chipp retired (he was a successful schoolteacher and administrator), I asked him what it was like being home so much. He said that he and Catherine led different lives and had different passions. They shared what they shared, but "I do not impinge on her work." They had supper and breakfast together, but they ate lunch separately. When I asked how they collaborated, he pointed to their lush gardens. Catherine did the planting and harvesting, Fredrick said, and he did the heavy labor. They walked together, three miles a day. They read to each other; the Chipps carried out even the (usually solo) act of reading in relationship. This year they had gone camping in Florida for two weeks; all three children and their families, including eight grandchildren, had come along too.

When I interviewed the Chipps for the first time they were forty-seven, and I was struck by how attractive Mrs. Chipp was. "The lines on her face and her facial expressions were all happy," I wrote in my notes. It made her unusually pretty. More than that, it was clear that humor, one of the most adaptive coping tools of all, was a great Chipp favorite.

They teased each other constantly. At seventy-five Chipp called his wife into the room to help him retrieve a name. "My mind's a blank," he told her. "So what's new?" said she. It reminded me of an encounter with another Grant Study wife in a warm marriage. I asked the routine Study question about whether divorce had ever been considered. "Divorce, never," she replied without missing a beat. "Murder, frequently."

What about serious disagreements, though? I asked Mrs. Chipp how she resolved them. "There's nothing like losing your temper once in a while," she said. "It clears the air." But she said it with great good humor. Her husband had told me separately that he believed in bringing conflict out into the open. They got angry occasionally, yes. But covert hostilities had no place in their relationship, while passive aggression is the coping technique most associated with bad marriages. The conflict-avoidant Penns, in contrast, just endured their mutual despair.

When Chipp was eighty-three, he and Catherine participated in Robert Waldinger's study of marital intimacy. This recent development of the Grant Study is an example of how twenty-first-century social science is making attachment visible. Waldinger's team has done extensive neuropsychological testing on both members of consenting couples; they have also videotaped couples in discussion of a conflictual topic. Afterward, they telephone the partners individually every night for a week, to study their responses to the interaction (the "daily diaries" noted in Chapter 3). Waldinger is also compiling fMRIs on these couples, using the imaging study to visualize brain responses to positive and negative emotional stimuli.

Waldinger taped the Chipps as they discussed a pressing conflict situation concerning two very disabled relatives and what the Chipps should do about their care. Fredrick Chipp is a taciturn person; his wife is verbal and outgoing. But they didn't waste time or effort struggling over whose point of view would prevail; every comment either one of them made was aimed at the problem of their relatives, and moved them closer to a solution. They were a couple dancing beautifully together. The follow-up questions about the conflict discussion included a query about "trying to get my partner to understand." "We don't try; we do!" Mrs. Chipps interjected. For them, even conflict was filled with laughter.

After this intensive restudy, both Mr. and Mrs. Chipp at age eighty-five were rated as "securely attached"—attachment theory's healthiest classification, which implies among other things the kind of trust and comfort in a relationship that enable it to withstand the stresses of conflict and separation.⁹ They also did well in assessments of how they behaved to each other, scoring low on such variables as "derogation of partner" and high on "stated satisfaction," "care giving," and "loving behavior."

When that interviewer asked Chipp about his relationship with his wife, he replied, "I always felt this is somebody who has a lot of depth. Who has a soul within her that is something I'm able to plumb, frequently. When I read a book or when she reads a book, for a second you may be deep in one yourself, but you want to share it with that other person."

Mrs. Chipp put it this way: "I can't imagine not having him there. And this doesn't mean that we do everything together. . . . I would drive him crazy and he would drive me crazy. But we always know the other one is there and that we have this relationship and that makes us both very content. . . . We're very different. We're not different in what we like in life. We're very, very close in what we like in life."

Rereading my own interview notes, I found a comment to myself: “He was perhaps the happiest man in the Study.” I recalled the end of my interview with him five years before, when I had asked Chipp how he and his wife depended on each other. He looked off into space, choked up, and fought back tears. “Gosh,” he blurted out, “just by being there. If she goes first, it would be pretty traumatic.”

She did, and it was. Losing a spouse to death is often the most painful blow of old age.

John and Nancy Adams: Try, try again. Here’s a happy marriage that took longer to happen. It’s the story of the proper Bostonian I’m calling John Adams, Esquire. In the first half of his life he was married three times, but those marriages lasted only nine years in toto. He met his fourth wife at the age of forty-five and has spent the forty-two years since then living with her very happily indeed. In contrast, I’ll offer a few notes on the life of Carlton Tarryton, M.D., whom we met briefly in Chapter 5, and who also had three divorces and four wives.

Tarryton and Adams resembled each other a lot in their first twenty-five years. They came from unhappy and isolated childhoods, with parents who spent a lot of time away. (Blind raters reported that they would not have wished to endure the childhood of either of these men.) They were bad losers. They manifestly lacked self-discipline; Adams often played hooky, and they were heavy drinkers and irresponsible students in college, earning grades in the bottom tenth of the Grant Study spectrum. They were both among the small minority of men to whom Study investigators ascribed the traits “Poorly Integrated” and “Lack Purpose and Values.”

There were two big differences between them, though. John Adams had a sibling with whom he was close, and in his teens there had been a stepfather whom he deeply loved. At twenty he said about his stepfather, “I really liked him more than any person I have ever known.” Tarryton was an only child and never had a parental figure whom he admired.

By the time they were thirty, their lives were beginning to diverge. Tarryton, who had gone to medical school, was often drinking a fifth of whiskey a day. He was extremely careful to remain sober when he was working, but his engagement in his career was limited. He maintained that he believed in Christian Science and that he had become a doctor only for the paycheck; in actuality, however, he made less money than any other practicing physician in the Study. He became an active alcoholic, and destroyed his brief and allegedly happy fourth marriage when he fell off the wagon one time too many at age fifty. In despair, he gave up and took his own life.

Adams went on drinking heavily too. But he was always able to maintain enough control over his alcohol use that it didn’t lead to problems in his academic life or elsewhere. He was on the Law Review at Stanford. By forty he had won an award for public service, and made partner in an excellent firm in Boston. It wasn’t all good news. He married and divorced three women. But he had some insight into his marital problems, which were due, he thought, to his own “emotional immaturity coupled with the habit of gravitating to persons whose emotions were less stable than my own.”

After his third divorce he began drinking less and exercising more. And he met Nancy, who became his fourth wife. A highly competent and emotionally supportive person, she could stand on her own and even offer Adams some of the caretaking he needed instead of wanting him to keep her together all the time. (Some Study members with unhappy childhoods achieved gratifying lives by devoting themselves to those more needy than they, but this otherwise useful altruistic coping strategy served less well in marriage than in the rest of life. Marriage seems to work best when both parties can gratefully allow the other to bring them breakfast in bed.)

In his fifties, after seven years of marriage to Nancy, Adams was feeling so good that he confessed to “incurable optimism.” He stopped answering questionnaires for a while, but when he resumed at the age of sixty, he reported his marriage as “perfectly happy” and suggested that it was “maturity that makes this marriage work.” He explained that in his previous marriages he had been “attracted to weakness, and that all my previous wives had major flaws of a psychiatric character.” And thirty-two years after he and Nancy married, Adams wrote that it was not his career but his marriage that had “turned my life into an absolute joy.”

Adams retired young and began writing semi-autobiographical short stories, transmuting much of the pain of his early life into art. I was intrigued to note that the interviewer who met him when he was thirty and still very unsettled had perceived this fledgling lawyer as “sensitive, bright—like a writer of fiction.”

When Adams was eighty he was interviewed by Maren Batalden, who mistrusted his optimism; she granted that the marriage was “genuinely happy,” but gave his wife credit for this. But at eighty-eight he was as cheerful as ever. It was clear to me, too, that there was some exaggeration going on; his optimistic assertion that there had been no decline in his physical activities couldn’t possibly be true.

But so what? There were three times as many optimists among the happily married as among the unhappily married—a very significant difference. Samuel Johnson seems to have had a point when he quipped that a second marriage is the triumph of hope over experience. Besides, I reflected, if at eighty-five you’re still playing tennis, your only medicine is Viagra, and the happiest seven-year period in your life is “now,” neither your marriage nor your physical health can be all that bad, even if your glasses are a bit rose-colored.

It came as a surprise to me that bleak childhoods were not always associated with bleak marriages. As we saw in Chapter 4, warm childhood predicted both future trust in the universe and future friendship patterns. And it was very significantly associated with life flourishing as measured by the Decathlon. Still, Camille finished in the top quartile in that test. With the exception of a man’s closeness to his father, childhood environment did not predict stable marriage, and even where a warm paternal relationship was lacking, good marriages could be made—eventually. Indeed, marriage seemed to be a means for making good on a poor childhood. After almost fifty years of following disadvantaged youths, psychologist Emmy Werner noted that “the most salient turning points . . . for most of these troubled individuals were meeting a caring friend and marrying an accepting spouse. 10 Childhood trauma does not always blight our lives, and the good things that happen to us keep on giving. Restorative marriages and maturing defenses are the soil out of which new resilience and post-traumatic growth emerge.

So it was for both the College and Inner City men. The Chipps and Oliver Holmes had very happy childhoods. But for the men who didn’t, good marriage seemed to have been part persistence and part the luck of the draw—Gilbert meeting Sullivan. My mother used to say that two people who are healthy can easily have a good marriage, but a great marriage takes a lucky match between two neurotics. John Adams made one such reparative marriage; Adam Newman made another. Others from the Study have been illustrated extensively elsewhere. 11

Eben and Patricia Frost: The limits of containment. Fifty-four of the Grant Study men celebrated golden anniversaries in “so-so” marriages—marriages that were neither particularly conflicted nor particularly loving. Their relations with their children and siblings were as warm as those of the happily married; so were their general relationships and social supports. Their childhoods were no less caring, their adaptive styles no less good, and they remained sexually active no less long. So what was different? These men reported that they were “very content” very significantly less often than the happily married men in all aspects of their lives, and this general tendency might have influenced the way they perceived and reported on their marriages. They had been significantly less close to their fathers. Their objective health on average was not quite as good as that of the men in happier marriages, and they were somewhat less likely to have close and confiding relationships of any kind, in or out of marriage. But most critically, as Eben Frost’s story will make clear, not everyone brings to marriage the desire (or is it the capacity?) for intimacy.

Frost grew up in a family that was scratching an annual income of \$1,000 1939 dollars out of a Vermont hillside. He walked three miles each way to a two-room schoolhouse in the winter, and in the summer he worked on his parents’ dairy farm. He knew that he was lonely and that he needed a job where he could talk to people. By the time he was ten, in silent rebellion against endless chores, he had secretly decided to leave the farm forever. He would go to college and then to Harvard Law School. And that is exactly what he did.

There was little outward warmth in the Frost family. The Frosts cared for each other, but they never exactly said so. The father was described as “unruffled” and “a great man of character and old-world morality.” The mother “never let things prey on her mind.” She told the Study little about Eben except that he was nice to live with. “When we had a job around the house to be done with neatness, we called in Eben.” But feelings were not discussed. Eben told the Study psychiatrist, “The family bonds have been almost entirely lacking insofar as the tie of intimacy is concerned.”

Eben was valedictorian of his high school class; he “ran the school” during his time there. But he felt that his greatest strength was his “ability to make friends.” At college he preferred team sports, and what he enjoyed most about the law was always contact with his clients. When he first entered the Grant Study, he was observed to be “well-poised, extremely friendly, very active, forceful, and energetic.”

Even at eighteen, Frost knew that he paid a price for the self-sufficiency that got the jobs done around the house and then took him to Harvard. He knew the limits of his talent for friendship, too. He admired the kind of marriage in which couples become completely absorbed in each other, but he knew it wasn't for him. "Although I hate nobody," he said, "I'm sometimes afraid I can love nobody." At twenty-five, Frost said of himself, "I'm a very easygoing character," and twenty years later, "I'm the most reasonable of men." That sweeping globality of expression—a very easygoing character, the most reasonable of men—remained typical of Frost over years of interviews and questionnaires, and seemed to serve as something of a Distant Early Warning Line. It signaled pride in the extent of his extreme containment, but also an undertone of threat: thus far and no further. And he did appreciate that his sweet reasonableness could be infuriating to others. "I'm so self-sufficient, or something, that I actually don't have any rough spots. This does not mean that things are perfect, it's just that nothing really bothers me—and I'm well aware that this is not necessarily an ideal constitution—I've been this way all my life."

When he was in college, one observer called Eben "supernormal." Time did not produce much change in that regard. When I met him at his twenty-fifth reunion I thought he was supernormal too, except in matters of intimacy. Frost exemplified and embodied the feeling tone of the "so-so" marriages, which were faithful, harmonious, and enduring, but lacking in warmth. The Study, as I've said, made many and repeated queries about the men's marital situations, and this included engagement and wedding plans. Frost's answers were utterly unrevealing until at twenty-four he wrote with a laconic nonchalance worthy of Calvin Coolidge, "Married on furlough." Nothing more, even though it turned out that his marriage had been in the works for many months.

As Study queries continued, Frost went on replying in his characteristic compliant but circumspect way. Asked about marital problems, he wrote, "Only the stupid or the liars will say 'none,' but that is my answer." The years of follow-up suggest that he was neither dim-witted nor dishonest, but he was limited. At age thirty he wrote that his wife was the person in his life whom he most admired; at forty-seven he regarded his marriage as stable. His wife's personality, he said, produced no problems for him. But he knew that his permanent reserve was a problem for her. This concerned him, but—as he saw it—there was nothing to be done about it; it was just the way he was.

When I met him, Frost presented himself as a charming, extroverted, happy, outgoing man who was very interested in people. He was calm, incisive, and unambiguous, and he had a contagious ease about him. He was a good-looking man with a fine sense of humor, and at forty-seven he looked far more like an old-money museum trustee than an impecunious farm boy who had somehow grown up to practice law. He described all his activities in terms of other people. It was only when I tried to push him into discussing close relationships that the No Trespassing signs appeared. He balked like a horse, becoming less cooperative and more abrupt until I returned to less charged material.

When he was eighteen, the Study internist noted that he was in "extraordinarily good health." This remained true. At forty-seven, Frost had never spent a day in the hospital or missed work due to illness. For over thirty years he described his overall health as "excellent." He wasn't ignoring things, either; he went for regular physicals that turned up nothing worse than hemorrhoids. So much for the supposed dangers to one's health of keeping feelings locked away; Eben Frost never in his life found, or wanted, anyone to confide in.

When he was forty-seven, I ranked Frost among the top third in the Study in adjustment; later, in the Decathlon, he scored in the top tenth. According to him, his life was as smooth as silk. "My practice doesn't have pressure; I chose a career without tensions." And he added with his characteristic lordly sang-froid, "I am the most unpressured person that exists."

Once in a midlife assessment, Frost complained that he was unsatisfied in his law career, and was "doomed to frustration." He expressed a wish to have been a creative artist. But as always, he knew how to comfort himself in his frustration, and he knew how to take care of himself, too. He designed his own house. He became president of his suburban PTA. And by the time six years had passed, he had altered his professional life to give him the personal, caring contact that he craved. He was now responsible for training young associates and could say to me with the enthusiasm of the generative, "My job turns me on."

But for all his repeated assertions that he was "as easy to get along with as anyone who ever lived," things weren't quite so silky at home. He reported that his wife "engaged in a certain amount of nagging." When they went on vacation, she spent her time on the beach while he played golf. He understood very well that his avoidance of mutual dependency

was a loss to both of them, and that the greatest stress in his marriage was “her frustration over my unwillingness to let her get inside of me.” He himself didn’t crave that kind of connection, though. He knew that she sometimes felt shut out, but his view was that she let her problems “grow and grow unnecessarily.” He didn’t take kindly to weakness. He said of himself that “[m]y greatest weakness is not leaning on anybody.” Insight was always one of his strong suits, but it didn’t change him. In contrast, here’s Fredrick Chipp at the same age, responding to a question about what he did when he was upset about something. “I go to her,” he said of his wife. “I talk with her. It’s very natural and easy and helpful. I certainly don’t keep it to myself. She’s my confidant.”

One of Frost’s daughters wrote that in her parents’ years together, she had never seen them fight; equally revealing, she had never seen them affectionate. He had always been more loving with his grandchildren than with his own children, she said. His other daughter summed up the situation: “Frosts never say ‘I love you’ to their children.” But people who can’t hug their peers can hug puppies. And grandkids.

I interviewed Frost after he retired. He told me that he made sure to be out of the house all day and never “home for lunch.” When I asked how he and his wife depended on each other, he explained that his wife was “self-sufficient. She has different interests.” So had he, both recreational and relational. Besides occasionally going on trips, “we don’t get involved in what the other is doing.” He liked art, but “her interest in the symphony does not interest me.”

There was absolutely no tenderness or care in his discussion of his wife. She, during my brief meeting with her, betrayed no interest in the Grant Study or in her husband’s fifty-year involvement in it. The way he put it later was that there was “nothing pulling our marriage apart, but we are not bound together.”

People have intense reactions to a story like this. Like divorce, it evokes a lot of personal, and sometimes conflicted, associations. To the young and intense, it may sound like a tragic abdication of passion. To the old and tired, it may sound like a rueful reflection of all the dreams that never came true. To people living in marital war-zones, it may sound like a blessed relief. But personal reactions shouldn’t obscure the important lessons of the Frosts’ marriage.

One is that even in a population selected for health, as the College cohort was, pleasure in close relationship is not a predictable developmental achievement. It’s not a clear correlate of one kind of childhood or another. It’s not a black-or-white, yes-or-no kind of thing, either. The capacity for intimate marriage is near kin to the capacity for close friendship, and we tested that by asking the men to describe their closest friends. Virtually all women can describe close friends—in plural—but some men don’t have any. Like musical talent, the talent for closeness exists on a continuum; there’s a lot of room between a tin ear and perfect pitch. To some extent the skills and pleasures of closeness can be practiced and learned; John Adams learned them. But not everyone will become a virtuoso. And, as Eben Frost demonstrates, not everyone wants to.

Eben Frost mastered Eriksonian Intimacy in a way that Peter Penn and Algernon Young never did. But he had no interest in intimacy of other kinds. Godfrey Camille, in contrast, actively sought closeness; for him it was a life quest. John Adams kept trying to establish for himself a relationship in which closeness would be possible, and once he had one, he really worked at it—that was one of the adaptive aspects of his marriage. For Frost, as he made very clear, closeness was not a desideratum. And he enjoyed his life thoroughly.

A comfortable, productive, and enduring marriage like Frost’s is no mean accomplishment, and for people without the desire for intense emotional closeness, it may be the best kind there is. It endured for fifty years without rancor or regret, and it gave its participants something closely approximating the modest levels of companionship they were looking for. If Patricia Frost complained sometimes that her husband’s preferred level of intimacy did not precisely match her own, she too, by her daughter’s report, appears to have been a person comfortable with more distance than with less.

Still, the Frosts’ marriage makes me (and their daughters) a little sad. The capacity for emotional intimacy is not a moral virtue, and its lack is neither a sin nor a failure. But it is a blessing. A marriage like the Frosts’ reminds us of how it feels to look for closeness and not find it.

Another provocative issue is the place of dependence in a successful marriage. Dependence is a dirty word these days; codependence is an even dirtier one. But mutual dependence is still allowed, and Study data suggest that some kinds of mutual dependence count among the apparently pathological adaptations that can in fact be healing. As I said in the last chapter, the most dependent adults came from the most unhappy childhoods. We’ve already seen (in Adam Newman and

Sam Lovelace, for instance) that marriage, however imperfect, is an opportunity to assuage some of the loneliness of bleak early years. It turned out that happy marriages after eighty were not associated either with warm childhoods or with mature defenses in early adulthood—that is, you don’t have to start out “all grown up” to end up solidly married.

Even when it isn’t needed for repair, mutual dependence has its own pleasures. Study transcripts from the happily married are full of unapologetic paeans to mutual dependence. As Catherine Chipp said in one of her interviews, “It’s very strengthening to have a person that you can always turn to.” Eben Frost’s story illustrates how the growth of closeness can be thwarted by too fierce a resistance to dependence. And it’s worth noting that friendship and mutual dependence in marriage deepen late in life. There are three primary reasons for this. First, the so-called empty nest is often more of a blessing than a burden. Second, the age-related hormonal changes that “feminize” husbands and “masculinize” wives make for a more level physical and emotional playing field. Third, physical infirmities make it ever plainer to both parties that mutual dependence is an advantage rather than a weakness. The deepening of dependence in marriage appears to correspond with a period of increasing subjective happiness as marriages age. More about this in a moment.

GOOD AND BAD MARRIAGES: SOME STATISTICAL DIFFERENCES

Table 6.2 depicts some of the relationships between Study variables and marital outcome. Most of them are self-evident. Divorce was most common among the alcoholic and the feckless, while bad marriages tended to endure among depressed men and men with bleak childhoods. The men with intact poor marriages were significantly more likely to have been depressed and to have used antidepressants or tranquilizers. As the lives of Newman and Adams suggest, while unhappy childhoods may lead to many ills in adult life, they do not preclude creating (or lucking into) a marriage good enough to help heal past miseries.

MARRIAGE AND SEX

There is one conspicuous missing piece in the Grant Study data set, and that is the sexual behavior of the Grant Study men as adults. We know a certain amount about the men’s sexual attitudes as sophomores, because that was a major interest of the early investigators. Over half the men expressed serious worries about masturbation to the Study psychiatrists: “It caused my acne, and other people could tell”; “I feared I would go crazy, become impotent, or damage my penis”; “Greatest problem in my life.” By modern standards, the men’s training (or lack of it) in sexual matters seemed quite repressive. We also know that in 1938 almost two-thirds of the men were strongly opposed to sexual intercourse before marriage: “I am disgusted with the idea of sexual relations”; “It is out of the question, nauseating”; “It would do something to my personality.”

Table 6.2 Correlates of Good and Bad Marital Outcomes

* The total N in Table 6.2 is 159 rather than the 242 in Table 6.1 due to the exclusion of the 73 so-so marriages, the 7 never married, and 3 missing data.

Of course we were very interested in adult sexual adjustment, but it didn’t take long for the Study staff to notice that a questionnaire that delved too inquisitively into the men’s sex lives was a questionnaire with a very low return rate. Over the years, therefore, the only information we systematically gathered on this subject were responses to a simplistic and rather ritualized question: Did a man perceive his sexual adjustment as “very satisfying,” “satisfying,” “not as good as wished,” or “poor”?

What we found was that overt fear of sex was a far more powerful predictor of poor mental health than sexual dissatisfaction in marriage was. After all, marital sexual adjustment depends heavily upon the partner, but fear of sex is closely linked with a personal mistrust of the universe. The men who experienced lifelong poor marriages were six times as likely as men with excellent marriages, and twice as likely as men who divorced, to give evidence on questionnaires of being fearful or uncomfortable about sexual relations. Yet there were many good marriages in which sexual adjustment was less than ideal after the couple reached age sixty. We can’t yet say much about why, or about what role biology may play.

Apart from that I don’t have much of interest to report on the men’s sex lives, except for one oddity of exactly the sort that makes lifetime studies so unpredictable and so fascinating.

At age eighty-five, we asked the men when they had last engaged in sexual intercourse. Only sixty-two (about two-thirds) of the men responded; of those 30 percent were still sexually active. In that small sample, the predictors of sustained sexual activity were: good health at sixty and seventy, good overall adjustment after (but not necessarily before) age sixty-five, and an absence of vascular risk factors. Surprisingly, the variables I thought would protect against early impotence—ancestral longevity, maturity of defenses, physical health at age eighty, and quality of marriage—showed no significant effect.

But I empirically defined a composite variable called cultural and impractical, summing five “touchy-feely” traits that had not been considered promising back in 1938—Creative/intuitive, Cultural, Ideational, Introspective, and Sensitive affect—and then subtracting from them the two practical traits that had largely been seen as laudable—Pragmatic and Practical/organizing. I chose these items because they correlated at least weakly with prolonged sexual activity. The result was not only very significantly correlated with a long sex life, but it also allowed a startling and dramatic separation of the Grant Study men by politics (more on this in Chapter 10, and on the curious association of the men’s political beliefs with sustained sexual activity).

DIVORCE REVISITED

Thirty-five years ago I was largely wrong about the importance of divorce. It is clear to me now that divorce does not necessarily reflect an inability to achieve Eriksonian Intimacy or even to enjoy great relational closeness. Divorce is often a symptom of something else. Ultimately, a man’s ability to cherish his parents, his siblings, his children, his friends, and at least one partner proved a far better predictor of his mental health and generativity than a mistaken early choice in his search for love.

There is unequivocal evidence that divorce occurs more frequently among people with every kind of mental illness.¹² But divorce does not imply mental illness. On the contrary, when a marriage is chronically unhappy, only divorce allows for the possibility of a new and better one. Most of us carry on an internal debate when a friend is considering ending a marriage. Divorce raises all kinds of personal anxieties about the safety of our relationships. It violates our sense of family stability and ruptures religious vows. It rarely makes for happy children. Yet it can also be a breakout from outworn social codes, chronic spousal abuse, or simply a bad decision. So it was interesting to compare the final remarriages of the divorced men with the marriages of men who remained unhappily with their first wives. The reasons for divorce had been one of Arlie Bock’s founding questions when he first proposed the Study; he had appreciated all the way back in 1938 that it could only be answered in the context of lifetimes.

One man who stayed in a bad marriage wrote, “This marriage will stick, if for no other reason than we’re a couple of stuffy, latter-day Victorians who just wouldn’t face divorce anyway.” Another wrote, “The marriage is stable if you will accept that it is held together as much by decision as by desire.” “Divorce is pretty unthinkable,” wrote a third, “so I grin and bear it. . . . Our marriage would have ended probably 15 years ago but for religion and the presence of children.” Religion and children were the two reasons usually cited for staying together among the enduring bad marriages.

The characteristic adaptive styles of the two groups of men were different. The men who remained in unhappy long marriages were more likely to be passive in other aspects of their lives than those who sought divorce, and less likely to use humor as a coping mechanism than the men who made the happiest remarriages. Their mental health was less robust in that they had had significantly more recourse to psychotherapy and to mood-altering drugs in an attempt to self-medicate. They were also less likely to have had warm childhoods in their pasts, or to enjoy rich social supports in old age.

The endurance of some bad marriages, however, seemed to involve loyalty to a depressed or alcoholic partner. Of the forty-nine men with lifelong excellent marriages, no men and only two wives abused alcohol, and only one man was mentally ill. But in forty-eight lifelong bad marriages, eleven men were alcoholic, nine had alcoholic wives, and seven were depressed. Some of these marriages endured out of codependency (as in the case of Lovelace’s first marriage), and somewhere one of the spouses was caretaker to the other, as in Albert Paine’s last one. And even unhappiness in marriage isn’t an all-or-nothing affair; three of these husbands reported at least one period when the marriage was excellent. Perhaps these are cases where hope died hard; as we’ve seen, the capacity to hope has a lot to be said for it.

CONCLUSION

So what do the seventy-five years of the Grant Study have to teach us about marriage, intimacy, and mental health? For one thing, they make clear that Lewellen Howland was right—the important thing is that “loving people for a long time is good.” Why? Well, for one reason, as I said at the outset, it feels good. Most of us enjoy love when we can get it. But in developmental terms, both intimacy and positive mental health reflect the process of replacing narcissism with empathy, a progressive amalgam of love and social intelligence that is essential to the development of mature defense mechanisms and optimum adaptational skills (Chapter 8).

The Study also makes abundantly clear that people don’t drink because they’re in bad marriages, but that drink makes marriages bad. For twenty-eight men, happy marriages became unhappy following the onset of alcoholism in a partner; in only seven cases did alcoholism first become obvious following a failing marriage, and in some of them the “failing marriage” was clearly less a cause than a rationalization for the loss of control over alcohol. Popular belief notwithstanding, alcohol is a very bad tranquilizer.

Third, we learn something about why the percentage of happy marriages increases after seventy. It is known from studies of the general population that the divorce rate declines sharply with increasing age and length of marriage. 13 Explanations for this include the selective weeding out over time of vulnerable marriages, increasing commitment and resistance to change with increasing age, and perhaps the fact that greater joint assets make divorce more expensive. A decline in divorce rate is not necessarily the same thing as increased marital happiness, but increased happiness is what our data showed. During the period from age twenty to seventy, only 18 percent of both partners from the entire sample reported their marriages as happy for at least twenty years. By age seventy-five half of the surviving men did. And by eighty-five, the proportion of happy marriages had risen to 76 percent. Some of this improvement no doubt has to do with Laura Carstensen’s theory of socioemotional selectivity, which suggests that as people get older they tend to remember the good over the bad. 14 Some seems to relate to the men’s increased tolerance for mutual dependence as they aged; as George Bancroft said, contemplating the loss of his once-cherished driver’s license, “You let your wife learn about you. . . .” Certainly the more the men became able to appreciate shared dependence as an opportunity rather than a threat, the more positive feelings they expressed about their marriages. Successful remarriage after divorce or widowhood was another contributing factor.

But the Grant Study offers an unexpected finding that even first marriages improve late in life. This is something that we would have been very unlikely to discover from a shorter or less comprehensive study. After age seventy, the men just seemed to find their marriages more precious. “Jane and I are at the age where what life we have left together is like the last few days of a great vacation,” one seventy-eight-year-old Study member said. “You want to get the most out of them, so we want to get the most out of our togetherness.”

Finally, the Study illuminates some subtle but vital distinctions that can’t be perceived at all except through the long lens of lifetime study: the difference between facile optimism like Alfred Paine’s (see Chapter 7), for example, and the lifelong faith in the universe of a Boatwright or an Adams. One is mere glitter; the other is true gold. Codependency may be a very false friend, but it was the capacity for mutual dependency that allowed the Chipps to share a warmth and comfort that the competent but chilly Frosts couldn’t offer each other.

And the lives of men like John Adams and the others who turned my thinking about marriage upside down remind us again of the remarkable reality that people continue to change, and people continue to grow. An interviewer once asked Margaret Mead to what she attributed the failure of her three marriages. “I don’t know what you mean,” she answered. “I had three successful marriages, all for different developmental phases of my life.” 15